



Q

Why must you add bottled lemon juice or citric acid when canning tomatoes?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

To ensure the acidity is high enough for safe processing

FUN FACT

Tomatoes are borderline acidic, so adding acid prevents harmful bacteria growth.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What is the safe method to remove skins from tomatoes before canning?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Dip tomatoes in boiling water for 30 to 60 seconds, then in cold water and slip off skins

FUN FACT

Heating helps loosen tomato skins quickly, making them easier to peel.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Teens (14–18)

Q

What can happen if you change the tested salsa recipe ingredients when canning?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

It can change acidity and make the salsa unsafe to preserve

FUN FACT

Even small recipe changes can affect food safety in canning.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

When canning salsa with hot peppers, why should you wear gloves?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

To avoid getting pepper oils on your skin and eyes, which can cause irritation

FUN FACT

Pepper oils can cause painful irritation; gloves protect your skin and eyes.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What is the recommended headspace when filling jars with tomato-based salsa for canning?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

1/2 inch headspace

FUN FACT

Proper headspace allows food to expand and forms a good vacuum seal.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

Which processing method is safe for canning tomato salsas?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Boiling water canner for acidified salsa recipes

FUN FACT

Boiling water canners reach high enough temperatures to destroy harmful microbes in acidic salsas.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

Why is it unsafe to increase the amount of onions, celery, or peppers in canned spaghetti sauce recipes?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Adding more lowers acidity, requiring different processing times which may not be safe

FUN FACT

Adding more vegetables without adjusting the recipe can make canned food unsafe.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What type of vinegar should be used in salsa recipes for safe canning?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Vinegar with 5% acidity

FUN FACT

Only vinegar with at least 5% acidity safely prevents botulism in canned salsas.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Teens (14–18)

Q

What should you do with the hottest peppers before adding them to salsa to make peeling easier?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Place peppers in a hot oven or on the stovetop until skins blister, then cover with a damp cloth

FUN FACT

Blistering the skins helps loosen them for easy peeling.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What is the minimum amount of bottled lemon juice to add per pint jar when canning tomatoes?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

1 tablespoon

FUN FACT

Adding acid prevents growth of dangerous bacteria in canned tomatoes.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

Why is it important to use tested recipes specifically for canning salsas?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

They have been scientifically tested to ensure safety and prevent botulism

FUN FACT

Safety testing means trusted recipes will keep your canned food safe to eat.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Teens (14–18)

Q

If you do not add the recommended acid to tomatoes before canning, what risk increases?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

The risk of botulism poisoning increases

FUN FACT

Botulism is a deadly bacteria prevented by adjusting acidity before canning tomatoes.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What is the purpose of simmering salsa after combining ingredients before packing jars?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

To blend flavors and reduce the mixture properly for safe processing

FUN FACT

Simmering helps thicken salsa and kills some microbes before canning.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What kind of jars should be used for canning tomatoes and salsas at home?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Standard Mason-type jars designed for home canning

FUN FACT

Mason jars can withstand high heat and create vacuum seals needed for safe home canning.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Teens (14–18)

Q

Why must the rims of jars be wiped clean before placing lids when canning salsa or tomatoes?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

To remove food bits that may prevent a proper seal

FUN FACT

A clean jar rim helps make an airtight seal to keep canned food safe.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

When canning tomato-pepper sauces, what is a safe processing method?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Use a pressure canner to process jars at the correct pressure and time

FUN FACT

Pressure canners can reach temperatures high enough to kill bacteria in low-acid tomato-pepper foods.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

Why should you not reuse metal canning lids after opening canned salsa or tomatoes?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Because they may not seal again properly and risk contamination

FUN FACT

New lids are designed for one-time use to keep your canned food safe.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Teens (14–18)

Q

How should you test a pressure canner's dial gauge for accuracy?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Have it checked at your local Extension office or a professional annually

FUN FACT

An accurate gauge ensures the correct pressure for safe home canning.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What is an important safety tip when handling hot chili peppers during salsa preparation?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Wash hands thoroughly with soap and water before touching your face or eyes if you don't wear gloves

FUN FACT

Capsaicin oils in hot peppers can irritate eyes and skin if hands aren't washed properly.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

Which acid can be substituted for bottled lemon juice in canning tomatoes?



Teens (14–18)

ANSWER

Bottled lime juice or citric acid

FUN FACT

Only bottled juices are tested to have the right acidity for safe canning.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables